

CORPORATE STRATEGY GROUP PROJECT

Pick ONE company that you are reasonably familiar with and are allowed to openly discuss. You are now hired as a consulting team to identify ONE (1) key issue in the firm's current corporate strategy, and to give recommendations for the future. Examples of corporate strategy issues include, but are not limited to, the following:

- Should they acquire/merge with/spin off a certain entity?
- Should they enter/exit a certain market segment?
- Do they have too many/few brands to manage? How to improve coordination across them?
- Should they centralize/decentralize the organization of certain business units?
- Should they expand to/exit a certain country?
- How to align the company's strategy in country x with the corporate goals?

Note that expansion is not for everyone. It is perfectly fine if, after careful analysis, you recommend the firm to stay put with no change, or to be a single-business pure-play domestic company.

Final write-up:

- Your submission should take the form of a letter to the top management team of the focal company, in a Word or PDF file. Your letter should be no more than 10 pages (single-spaced), including figures, tables and references. You can choose the specific format of the letter.
- You may refer to books, notes, or online sources, but have to write in your own words (unless accompanied with quotation marks and references). You are encouraged to collect first-hand information through interviews.
- Your letter should contain answers to the following questions:
 - a. Why does the issue you identified deserve the attention from the top executives? (stated in your proposal)
 - b. What do you think are the unique resources of the focal firm? What allowed this firm (but not the others) to possess such resources?
 - c. Assess the external competition the company is facing. Does the current industry structure merit any consideration in your recommendation? (The answer may be no, but you still need to assess the environment before you know the answer.)
 - d. What's the optimal organizational structure for your recommended move? Autonomy? Centralization? Integrated or not?
 - e. How does your recommended move affect its overall competitive advantage in the industry? After all, having a profitable unit is not enough if it hurts the long-term prospect of the firm.
- Use the concepts and frameworks discussed in class, but please be selective. Do not run a laundry list of all the factors. Instead, find the ones most relevant to your analysis.
- If some crucial information is not readily available, discuss where to obtain the information or how to make decisions with incomplete information (which we do all the time). Good understanding of concepts and logical clarity are more important than the amount of information compiled.

In-class presentation

- All presentations will be in the last two sessions of the class. The order of the presentation will be randomly generated before class.
- All presentation slides should be uploaded to Canvas (under Presentation Slides) the night before.
- Each team will have no more than 10 min for presentation, followed by 10 min of Q&A. The presentation will be graded based on (1) research (efforts), (2) logical clarity (content), and (3) communication (delivery). Note that completeness is not one of the criteria. The presentation is NOT an overview of your entire project, nor is it a showcase of your conclusion. You are encouraged to ask your classmates for help on specific issues or seek their opinions on your thoughts. Good questions are as good indicators of your understanding as sound conclusions.
- While most teams choose to be on stage together, it is fine to have some—or even one—of the team members presenting for the whole team. Regardless of who is presenting, the presentation should be clearly the result of team work, and all team members are expected to be present, offer support, and participate in the Q&A. Absences from the presentations will be treated the same as absences from any regular class.